We should have a glue to stick us together unless your shareholders do not agree. And that glue is a common logo and the second is the way we work, following the TBEM.' A small fee had, however, to be paid to Tata Sons for the use of the brand name and it was made a part of the BEBP agreement.

Not all supported the proposal. Though Ravi Dubey, vice president, Tata Services Limited, explained that the branding exercise was simply a 'marketing decision as the House of Tatas wanted to fully utilize the brand equity of the company', several investors thought otherwise.

Some critics also questioned the justification for companies like Taj and Titan to pay for a branding that they did not use. Ratan, however, disagreed with this assertion. He said that both companies had benefited from the association with the group, since, as a *Financial Times* study had concluded, 'Tata is the most powerful Indian brand name internationally.'

Ratan's key point was that the name Tata is emblematic of quality. It immediately conjures up in the mind of a customer an assurance of reliability and quality. The chairman drove home the point with a strong analogy. He said that if a 'NELCO TV set blows up in someone's face, or a Rallis fan fails, then suddenly the buzz is that we didn't expect this from a Tata company'. Speaking independently around twenty-six years later, Sunil Bharti Mittal, founder and chairman of Bharti Enterprises, said that 'Tata' stands for 'trust' and the assurance of 'quality' and a 'particular standard' and this guarantee is worth hundreds of billions of dollars.

The name 'Tata' did not evoke notions of trust only in India, but also in the most discerning and faraway markets of the world, in an age when the world was not as connected as it is today. When JRD travelled to the US to raise funds for TISCO's expansion programme in September 1957, he found that the group's reputation had preceded him. 'No one doubted that the reputation and credit of Tata would win him his additional funds from U.S. banks and investment houses,' wrote *TIME* magazine.

Despite opposition from some quarters, on 24 December 1998, the Tata Brand Equity and Business Promotion scheme was formally launched. The boards of seven 'principal' companies approved the signing of the agreement with the promoter. These included TISCO, TELCO, Tata Tea, Tata Chemicals, Tata Electric Companies, Tata International and Tata Industries. They were considered and approved by Tata Sons, which reserved the right to decide the companies with which such agreements would be signed.